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Clownfish Blues: A Novel (Serge Storms)

by Tim Dorsey

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93 Highlights | 1 Note

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 5

“Jesus, don’t buy lottery tickets,” said Serge. “The store won’t tell you this because they’re in on it, but the whole thing is a fool’s bet. It’s a tax on people who are bad at arithmetic.” “What the hell’s going on here? Just give me the tickets!” “Buy food instead,” said Serge. “That’s a sure thing.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 7

“I can’t believe they fired us,” said Coleman. “I was starting to get pretty good at that.” “Doesn’t matter,” said Serge. “We were going to quit tomorrow anyway.” “But we just started working there Monday.” “That’s right. We reached our time limit.” Serge pulled a lottery ticket from his pocket and gently caressed the image of a loggerhead turtle. “It’s the key to our new lifestyle choice, moving on to a new town every week and getting another job, just like all the classic American TV road shows: Route 66, The Fugitive, Branded, Kung Fu, and the all-but-overlooked Sea Hunt, starring Lloyd Bridges. None of them ever stayed more than a week.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 7

Even rebels must answer to the prime-time network schedule.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 8

High above the road stood the familiar flamingo logo with a tropical splash of colors that promoted wealth without work.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 14

“Do you actually know anything about worm-grunting?” “Everything,” said Serge. “Do I look like some kind of amateur? You fashion a foot-and-a-half wooden stake made of persimmon or oak that’s called a ‘stob’ and pound it into nutrient-rich soil. Next you take an equal length of metal known as a ‘rooping iron’ that’s often a leaf spring salvaged from the suspension of an abandoned truck. Then you rub the iron over the top of the stob to mimic the frequency of the earthworm’s mortal nemesis, digging moles. Consequently, your quarry flees to the surface, and before you know it”—he snapped his fingers—“you’re tits-high in earthworms. Lower property taxes for everyone!”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 15

“Where’d you learn all that?” “Books, Internet.” “But have you actually done it?” “Knowledge trumps experience,” said Serge. “Einstein never built an A-bomb, but ask a certain country how that turned out.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 18

“We have to get the hell out of here!” Serge threw the Stingray in gear as a disheveled woman staggered out in a daze and pulled up a bra strap. “Wait! Why are you leaving?” “To protect you,” Serge yelled as he hit the gas. “There are a lot of serial killers running around. Luckily it was just me this time, but you need to be more careful.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 19

Then came a sea change in the industry near the turn of the millennium. The Internet had dwindled readership to the point that vulture capitalists could acquire most papers for less than the cost of the land under the buildings.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 20

said Rock, his short sleeves rolled all the way up to reveal tattoos of the Chinese symbols for love and hate. Except the tattoo artist had been coming off a mule-kick hangover, and the designs ended up saying love and storage unit.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 21

You know how journalists can get.” “Right,” said Reevis. “We’re supposed to be aggressively curious about everything except malfeasance in our own company.” “And sarcastic,” said Shug. But he was old school, too, and liked that about Reevis.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 22

“Remember when CNN was all news, all the time?” “Sure. They cast the mold.” “Then ratings began to slip, so they began filling prime time with reality shows. People working weird jobs, celebrity psychiatrists, Anthony Bourdain drunk in the Alps.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 23

“Then there’s Deadliest Dig, a true-life look at the outrageously harrowing world of worm-grunters in the Apalachicola Forest.” “What are worm-grunters?” “They trudge miles across the muck to catch earthworms for fishing-bait stores.” “Doesn’t sound dangerous.” “They also solve crime.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 23

We already have a full lineup of shows where people solve crime, like the ones I already mentioned, plus Seminole blackjack dealers, retired circus people, glassblowers who don’t trust outsiders, Jell-O shot waitresses,

the Wives of Jiffy Lube . . .” “Where is this going?” asked Reeves. “Don’t you see? That’s the beauty of it. That’s the whole genius!” said Nigel. “These other people didn’t know anything about detective work before we came along. But you actually have extensive experience investigating crime for a living. It’s so crazy it just might work!”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 28

“Having sex with her was my obligation to the fidelity of the TV series. On the other hand, we’re out to revolutionize worm-grunting, and intercourse always blunts your edge in a drive to the championship. Remember in Raging Bull how Robert De Niro shunned sex and put ice in his underpants before a prizefight? A few orgasms probably won’t cost me many pails of worms, but why roll the dice?” “So when you told her about all the serial killers running around?” “Trying to let her down easy,” said Serge. “During a breakup, you can hem and haw about ‘No, it’s not you; it’s me,’ but that can drag on for weeks. Jump right to ‘serial killers’ and it’s a clean break.” “I admire you,” said Coleman.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 29

“Hardware stores are the opposite of Pottery Barns. If the two ever collided in deep space, they would explode like matter and anti-matter.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 29

“You always know where you stand in a Home Depot.” “They should call it the No-Bullshit Depot,”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 40

“Nature enthusiasts and the U.S. Navy use hydrophones to listen to majestic whales or enemy submarines, depending on which lifestyle they signed up for.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 47

The police took statements from the women before leading the future ex-landlord away in cuffs.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 49

“You boys just make yourself at home . . .” Behind them, Willard poured clear liquid into a pair of mismatched coffee mugs. “Easy with this stuff if ya ain’t used to it.” “Don’t worry about me.” Coleman took a stiff pull. “What do ya think?” asked Willard. No answer. Coleman stood perfectly still, surprised eyes indicating an internal security breach. Then he suffered a brutal coughing fit that brought tears and drool. “You better set yourself down.” Coleman waved him off and pounded his chest, then jiggled his coffee mug, signaling for another pour. “You sure?” Coleman nodded firmly. “Damn,” Willard said as he unscrewed the jar again. “Hey, Jasper, this one’s got some tough bark on him.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 50

“Even country restaurants don’t have a likin’ for the words ‘swamp cabbage’ on their menu, so they call it heart of palm, which is the tasty soft bulb you cut out of the trunk just below the base of the leaves. Cabbage palmetto, also known as—” “Sabal palm,” said Serge. “The state tree. They probably would have picked the coconut palm, but needed something that also grew in Florida’s northern latitudes.” “You sure nuff know your facts.” Serge took another bite. “I’m getting a party in my mouth, but I can’t place all the guests.” “Chop up the hearts with some onion, add a beaten egg, lots of pepper and bacon fat,” said Jasper. “‘Cept I just also add the bacon itself ’cuz life’s too short. Then some flour makes the patties.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 53

She headed outside, where the evening air was filled with happy shouts, singing and gunfire.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 55

I’d bet the farm that he’s already cleaned her out.” “But if that’s true, why is he still there?” “Why not? If he doesn’t have much drive in life, he’s living there free in a spare bedroom, cashing her Social Security check each month, and propping his feet up on empty cases of Mallomars.” “And military benefits from her late husband, Homer,” said Lou Ellen. “Plus I’m sure her life insurance policy has a new beneficiary,”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 55

“Wish it weren’t true, but this is such a common scam in Florida that the authorities have trouble keeping up,”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 57

Just over a decade ago, there were a couple of back-to-back hurricane seasons that made even lifelong Floridians go “Damn.” For the first time ever, the weather service ran out of pre-chosen names for storms, and had to go deep into the Greek alphabet before the year was out.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 64

“Florida is a two-party consent state for recording conversations. We’ll be committing a felony.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 70

“Can you dig it? We’re on a Route 66 bender! I know what you’re wondering: What’s Route 66 got to do with Florida? And that’s what everyone thinks! People just assume that all the shows were filmed along the iconic ‘Mother Road’ highway from Chicago to Los Angeles. But the title had broader implications of unstructured life on the road during the post-Kerouac zeitgeist. I hate people who use the word ‘zeitgeist’ and yet I just did. That makes me a complicated, non-one-issue voter. So the Route 66 producers roamed all over the country and—hold on to your hat—near the end they filmed a dozen shows in Florida, including the double-episode series finale in Tampa! I guess they knew the show was winding down in the winter and figured, ‘Do we want to shoot in Detroit or Daytona?’ Tough choice, right?

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 76

Reevis could feel the heat from the eyes across the bar. The regulars became more hostile in their glares. The only thing holding them back was Clementine's de facto approval of the young reporter. You don't shit where you eat, and you don't cross bartenders in your zip code.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 76

"Sanchez keeps pestering me, raising his hands to heaven and saying, 'It's a sign from God!' Tells me it's brand new, driver door open, keys in the ignition, and a holy glow inside telling him the saints wanted him to have the car. I said that was the dome light,

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 80

"This is everything I was trying to tell you," said Reevis. "Your antics provoked an unknown variable that nobody could predict or control. That isn't crime reporting! If you're in the woods and see a gigantic bees' nest, you go around it. You don't say, 'Reevis, get a big rock and whack that thing open and we'll film whatever happens next.' We lost the camera, my interview, and your precious confrontation footage. Am I missing anything?" "Wait," asked Nigel. "Are you saying you actually know where there's a gigantic bees' nest?"

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 81

Serge scanned the forest and spotted the captive trudging away off balance like a primitive robot.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 83

or CEO who uses overseas factories so deplorable they're forced to fence in the rooftops because workers would rather jump than make another fucking game box."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 84

the documentary said that one or two percent of the total population are psychopaths. Apparently the gold standard of figuring out which neighbors to keep an eye on is something called the Hare PCL-R test. I took it online, and I got a great score! Then I found out that a great score is not good. Maybe I should have studied harder.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 84

As I explained earlier, the sound waves drive up the worms, which will begin crawling on you and—sorry, this part is a little gross—some will fall in your mouth. But the sonic device behind it all is running on battery power, so if you can outlast the life of the power supply by eating enough earthworms, then they won't suffocate you. I know you drew one of my most distasteful contests, but on the other hand, they're an incredible source of protein. Well, that about does it. See you on the flip side . . ."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 84

“Now then, as I alluded earlier, psychopaths are adept at climbing company ladders because they’re easily able to make draconian decisions that would leave the rest of us sleepless for weeks.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 84

Did you know that if a colonoscopy turns up a polyp, any doctor will advise you to come back for another test within three years or risk inoperable cancer? Yet some insurance companies refuse to authorize follow-up tests for ten years. Know why? An executive did the harm–profit ratio and decided that at ten years, there was an acceptable fifty percent survival rate—for something that’s virtually one hundred percent preventable with timely screenings. Now, if that isn’t treating the customers like livestock.” Serge nodded to himself with conviction. “A psychopath made that decision.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 88

“I am familiar with computers,” said Pelota. “If one is so inclined, anything can be achieved.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 91

“Will I ever see you again?” “Anything’s possible,” said Serge. “But you should be looking for someone who’s better suited for you.” “Where am I going to find anyone as kind, charming, intelligent, humorous, fun-loving . . .” “True, true,” said Serge. “Except there’s a lot you don’t know about me and Coleman.” “Coleman?” “We come as a package,” said Serge. “In a way, I’m his caretaker. He’d never last without me.” “See?” said Lou Ellen. “You’re so compassionate.” “True again. But trust me on this: There’s a significant downside to getting mixed up with us. Don’t be fooled if it’s not apparent for a long time—”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 93

A carpet-remnant outlet just held its eighth going-out-of-business sale, but the turnout was so anemic that they had to go out of business.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 93

Next to the store, two police cars sat side by side, facing opposite directions so the officers could talk through their open driver’s windows. In prison lingo, it’s called a sixty-nine.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 93

“What’s with these new street drugs?” said the other officer. “And why does Florida always get them first?” “We’re number one!”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 93

“I just don’t understand the drug fringe. And flakka is the worst yet. People pay good money for a substance whose primary effect is an overwhelming

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 94

“Is that an actual infraction?” A shrug. “Courts have upheld searches as long as we think it’s an infraction.” “I love the War on Drugs.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 99

It was still an ongoing investigation, so there was no public right to the documents. But the info officer had worked with Reeves before and knew he could be trusted—at least with the parts of the files he wanted the reporter to see. Another unwritten alliance in journalism: They both knew they were using each other, and everyone was content with the arrangement.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 106

Own it.” “Own what?” “Your life. We can discuss huge racial differences as long as it comes from a position of love, like telling your aunt at a funeral that she’s got toilet paper stuck to her shoe. Awkward, but you work through it as a family. The problem is the people who refuse to sit with us and break bread at the Great American Dinner Table. Why? Deep down they realize their lives suck, but they won’t own it.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 107

Naw, someone else did this to me.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 107

“Their entire life drive is to make others as miserable as they are,” said Serge. “There’s no excuse for that.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 108

“Rule number one in life: Windbreakers with stuff written on the back are the key to making nosy people step back so you can have room to work. Along with clipboards and orange cones, the Windbreaker is rarely questioned.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 108

“There’s no rule against putting whatever you want on the back of your own jacket—just no ‘Police’ or ‘SWAT’ or ‘ATF’—or you can be charged with impersonating a law enforcement officer.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 109

“People say this is a free country so often that it’s lost meaning. I’m only tapping into the possibilities that everyone else just assumes are off-limits simply because they lack the imagination to think of it themselves.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 109

“Right now, only law enforcement is doing that, but what’s to prevent a private citizen from taking it up as a hobby?” Coleman looked down at his jacket again: Hostage Negotiation Team. “But how will we find a place to use these?” “At any particular moment in Florida, an average of fifteen standoffs are under way,”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 111

Reevis let his neck relax over the back of the chair as he stared up at hypnotic holes in the particleboard drop ceiling.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 115

This is the last time I’m going to tell you to get out!” Serge walked over to the television. “Anything good on?” “Are you insane?” said the man. “I have a gun here!” “So do I.” Serge briefly raised his tropical shirt, then lowered it. “See? We’re off to an excellent start! Show-and-tell, gun for gun. We’re bonding! That’s what dudes always do the first time they visit each other’s crib. ‘Let me see all your coolest shit.’ If you were at my place, right now we’d be looking at View-Masters and a prize collection of souvenir flattened pennies, but since it’s your pad, we could be heading to the garage and an industrial cooler full of do-it-yourself shrunken heads, because America was founded on the principle of never judging a hobby.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 117

things that inexplicably bend people to your will. Same with calling someone ‘boss.’ It’s like handing a little kid one of those giant swirly lollipops. The general public doesn’t even realize it’s happening, but on a subconscious level: ‘Why yes, I guess I am kind of like the boss. And I’ve only known this person a few seconds, but for some reason, I really like him.’ Then it completely flips the hierarchical paradigm.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 120

“Rog, a Pottery Barn can test even the strongest man’s limits, which is why you always see them crying in the parking lot.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 120

Out in the street, Sergeant Duffy huddled with his corporal. “What do you think now?” “That negotiator must be for real. He got the hostage released faster than I’ve ever seen in my life.” “I was thinking the same thing,” said the sergeant. “I got nineteen years in for my pension. Can’t afford to mess this up.” “The only other explanation is they simply bought Windbreakers.” “Don’t be silly.” Duffy was also privately thinking: He called me “boss.” For some reason I really like this guy.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 121

The competition between the nail and beauty salons was heating up. More and more pink neon had recently been placed in the windows to advertise new services involving wax, cucumbers and heated stones.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 129

“Well, one of history’s best negotiators for my money was former U.S. senator George Mitchell, who hammered out the breakthrough Good Friday Belfast peace accords in 1998. You know his most brilliant tactic? He’d gather everyone together, and his only ground rule for the first day was that nobody could discuss what they were there to discuss.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 129

“Rog, you know any weed guys?” “Coleman!” said Serge. “What’s it always with you and the weed guys?” “I’m putting out feelers. Mine’s become unreliable.” “Of course he’s unreliable,” said Serge. “He’s a weed guy. That’s his job.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 130

I hate complaints about first-world problems:

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 140

what’s the opposite? An ‘empath’! They feel everything, the suffering of people they don’t even know in other countries, baby seals, the destruction of rain forests. Some of them are those former celebrities on late-night commercials with starving children who are forced to write you personal letters if you buy them rice and pencils during a drunken late-night moment of weakness, and now these letters of shame keep popping up each month like herpes. That’s why I hate the terms ‘bleeding heart’ and ‘tree hugger.’ Sure, they can get so annoying you want to ram knitting needles through both your ears. But deep inside, their intentions are wonderful. Jesus was an empath. Although today I’m tempted to tweak the Sermon on the Mount: ‘The meek shall inherit the earth, but only if their parents were greedy psychopaths’ . . .”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 143

Mart-Mart

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 150

“I’ve got to see the bedroom.” She strolled and stopped in the doorway. “A mattress on the floor and an alarm clock?” “Lifestyle aesthetics,” said Reevis. “I was concerned about losing my enthusiasm for all the little things.” “In other words, you got rid of distractions so you could be distracted?” “Something like that.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 150

I was just going through the motions flipping the switch on my Mr. Coffee. But this baby . . .” He held it at eye level and began twisting. “. . . You unscrew the bottom half and fill it with water. Then replace the perforated little metal chamber where you tamp down the coffee grounds. Turn the burner on and wait for the water to boil up and trickle out a post in the upper chamber. It takes a lot more time, but you can’t compare the taste.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 150

“Demitasse ablutions?”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 151

“Wilson Pickett’s recording from 1968 in Muscle Shoals, Alabama.” “You’re into Pickett?” “As much as the next guy.” Reevis oiled a frying pan and tossed the meat in with some garlic. “But the real reason I love this version is the big crescendo at the end when an unknown session guitarist from Florida nicknamed Skydog blew everyone away with an insane riff. Nothing like it had ever been heard on an R-and-B record. And today, that precise moment three minutes into the song is called the birth of Southern rock. Eric Clapton called it the best guitar solo he’d ever heard, so he tracked down Skydog, learned his real name was Duane Allman, and invited him to play guitar on Eric’s next album that they recorded in Miami.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 152

. ‘Shortly after the ‘Hey Jude’ session, Duane returned to Jacksonville and formed the Allman Brothers Band.’” Her eyes suddenly shot up to Reevis. “It’s signed ‘Serge!’” “He sends a package every week,” said the reporter. “Sometimes the return address is in the middle of Lake Okeechobee; sometimes the governor’s mansion.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 154

“Watercolor called A Norther, painted in Key West in 1886 by Winslow Homer. Now it’s my favorite painting of all time. I picked a spot in the apartment where I’d see it a lot.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 161

cite Ninth Circuit Appeals Los Angeles 1994. Vast majority of all big-city bills test positive, higher in Florida. Takes as little as point-zero-zero-six micrograms . . . No, only a tiny percentage of the currency has been handled by traffickers. The rest is cross-contamination from ATMs and currency counters at banks.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 164

these are real chemical compounds, forming lattice structures in compliance with the laws of the periodic table. This crystal may look totally solid, but most of it is actually empty space with electrons furiously orbiting shit, so who really knows what’s going on? Ironically, it’s science itself that causes me to be open-minded and insatiably curious about something apparently unscientific. Now I must do further research.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 166

“I didn’t realize this was so involved. The listings are rigidly divided between mediums and healers. All guaranteed to be officially certified and permitted.” Coleman tapped Serge on the back. “What kind of test do you think they give to certify them?” “Probably a blank piece of paper,” said Serge. “Then they turn it back in blank because the person grading the exam is also a psychic.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 176

Madam Bovary looked up in confusion. “You brought a toy?” “The Eight Ball is my quality-control element,” said Serge. “Like a double-blind test. I want to believe all this mumbo jumbo, but questions have arisen. For instance, since Cassadaga calls itself ‘The Psychic Capital of the World,’ then it should also be ‘The Lottery-Winning Capital.’ But where are all the mansions?” A theatrical smile. “Skepticism is healthy.” Serge checked the message window in his Eight Ball. “So far so good.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 177

“Let me have your hands . . .” She took them in hers. “Now close your eyes . . .” “They’re closed,” said Serge. “But this better not be a ruse to silence the Eight Ball.” “Shhhh, relax . . . Focus on a point in the center of your mind . . . Do you see anything? . . .” “It’s just dark with barely visible little blobs floating around, except when I try to look at one, it just floats off to the side. What is that fuckery?”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 180

to live out their years in isolation wearing palm-frond pants.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 198

“The number one rule in life is to promise everyone they can have everything they want at all times. Our whole presidential cycle depends on it,” said Serge. “Of course you can’t actually deliver on most of the stuff you promised, but in the short term, people you lie to are less douchey.”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 205

“The number one rule in life is when people point out that you lied, just flatly deny it. Of course The Daily Show will run clips of you saying it, but nobody’s paying attention. Don’t you follow elections in this country?”

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 214

“I’ve totally rededicated my life to the world of crystals. When I was in school, they told us neutrons and protons and electrons were as small as it gets. But now there are quarks, bosons, hadrons, gluons, which means I was seriously gypped!” He rummaged in the other bag, producing a pair of drinking glasses and bottles of spring water. “But here’s where all that science brings us to crystals. Most people think that only plants and animals are alive, and everything else isn’t. I mean, look at my car keys. Like crystals, they appear completely solid, but

inside, all these subatomic particles are racing around like they're late for something. So my keys are actually alive . . . Note to self: Don't just throw them on the dresser anymore . . ."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 220

"I've heard of situations where someone is buying up investment property and wants to shield their identity so the prospective sellers don't raise their prices. So they create some kind of trust where a law firm's name shows up on everything."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 226

They approached the counter. "Shovels and beer?" said the grizzled clerk. "You boys burying something?" "No!" He scanned in the purchase. "Then you must be digging something up." "W-w-why do you say that?" The clerk shrugged. "It's Friday night." Nigel and Günter rushed out of the store. The next customers stepped up to the counter. "Anything else?" asked the clerk. "Just the shovels and beer."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 227

"They sell them everywhere in the state. I bought these last week during our confrontational exposé on the dangers of gun shows." "Why?" "To be on the safe side."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 238

They dashed under the metal overhang and the sky cut loose, as it is known to do every afternoon in the Florida summer for fifteen minutes.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 239

"How come it rains every afternoon in the summer?" "Temperature differential because land heats up faster than the sea as the sun climbs into the sky, creating a pressure drop and pulling air and moisture in from the ocean."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 243

. . . When the SUV arrived on the scene, U.S. 1 was backed up all the way to downtown Miami. It wasn't congestion. It was rubbernecking. Drivers slowed and stuck their heads out windows and stared up.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 247

"The champagne of beers!"

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 248

"Miller gets me fucked up. That's all I know." "Now that's a slogan."

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 268

You're probably wondering why? Because Lowe's has a color scheme to attract chicks, and that's a slippery slope.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 277

"You like to yiff?" "Yippie!" "No, silly." She laughed. "You know, yiffing. I pegged you two as yiffers.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 289

Inside room number four, more detectives milled with Styrofoam cups of coffee. One of them eyed a box of cupcakes, but knew it would be wrong.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 298

"I'm always fascinated when I don't understand a major cultural phenomenon," said the cheetah. "I've seen hundreds of these nail places everywhere and can't grasp how they survive. Yet customers are always coming and going. Why would anyone pay good money when they can just bite?" "They can't reach their feet?"

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 311

"I love copy shops! Know why?" "Paper?" "Multi-cultural harmony." Serge nodded to himself. "I might just be the first person to recognize it, but copy shops are the ultimate bellwether of ethnic relations. We may eat different food, wear different clothes, but every race and creed needs copies." "Never thought about it that way." "And that's the mistake CNN makes. Every time there's some civil unrest somewhere, reporters descend and visit all kinds of businesses for interviews with the common man—breakfast diners, Starbucks, massage parlors—but never a copy shop."

Highlight (Yellow) and Note | Page 316

each of them was given a specific spread of permutations descending from fifty-three.

should be comment combinations... order is irrelevant with the lottery

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 317

Pelota had adopted a saying he'd picked up in prison. Don't get mad until it's time to get mad. He was roundly feared for his erratic and ruthless temper, but in truth his emotions were a highly polished chest of tools, and he orchestrated erraticism to an advantage.

Highlight (Yellow) | Page 334

A bleached-out lottery ticket with no visible numbers emerged from a spillway and floated off into the Atlantic Ocean. In the history of the Florida Lottery, there have been a number of unclaimed tickets. The largest jackpot that wasn't cashed by the 180-day deadline came in 2003 at \$53.7 million.

Tim Dorsey was a reporter and editor for the Tampa Tribune from 1987 to 1999, and is the author of nineteen previous novels: Coconut Cowboy, Shark Skin Suite, Tiger Shrimp Tango, The Riptide Ultra-Glide, Pineapple Grenade, When Elves Attack, Electric Barracuda, Gator A-Go-Go, Nuclear Jellyfish, Atomic Lobster, Hurricane Punch, The Big Bamboo, Torpedo Juice, Cadillac Beach, The Stingray Shuffle, Triggerfish Twist, Orange Crush, Hammerhead Ranch Motel, and Florida Roadkill. He lives in Tampa, Florida.
